Uncle Tom's Cabin

Harriet Beecher Stowe · 1852

Source: Harriet Beecher Stowe, Uncle Tom's Cabin (1852), Chapter VII. Public domain. Continuous passage.

> Stowe's bestselling antislavery novel made the human cost of slavery vivid to millions of Northern readers. In this famous scene, the enslaved mother Eliza flees across the ice-choked Ohio River to save her child from being sold.

Nerved with strength such as God gives only to the desperate, with one wild cry and flying leap, she vaulted sheer over the turbid current by the shore, on to the raft of ice beyond. It was a desperate leap — impossible to anything but madness and despair; and Haley, Sam, and Andy, instinctively cried out, and lifted up their hands, as she did it.

[. . .]

With wild cries and desperate energy she leaped to another and still another cake; stumbling — leaping — slipping — springing upwards again! Her shoes are gone — her stockings cut from her feet — while blood marked every step; but she saw nothing, felt nothing, till dimly, as in a dream, she saw the Ohio side, and a man helping her up the bank.